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AWKWARD AND OVAL

2006 WAS a year of conflict. I announced my retirement from Test cricket but soon came out of it and then announced it yet again. I was exhausted but also divided. Personally, I wanted to focus on limited-overs cricket but my friends and family wanted me to continue playing Tests. They had a point: some number-crunching will indicate that my Test career stats are more sound in comparison to my ODI career.

Frankly, I think my decision of leaving Test cricket was indeed a good one because I wasn't enjoying the format, personally. Yet, I didn't want to disappoint friends and family either – they have always played an important role in defining my career. Naturally, I was conflicted between choosing personal satisfaction over the expectations of loved ones.

Frankly, I was bored of Test cricket too. I couldn't play for five days. I couldn't play for five days if you paid me a million dollars per day. (On second thoughts, that's not such a bad offer and I may have reconsidered.) But seriously, Tests weren't my thing.

No *zabardasti,* boss, I said to myself. After all, I wasn't enjoying myself at the Test level. Before people blow my comment out of proportion, here's my official take: Test cricket is awesome. It's the ultimate form of cricket. It's what the spirit of cricket is based on. It's amazing, brilliant and brings out the best and the worst in players and their teams. But I've tested for Tests and have passed. I know that I'm done. Test cricket is not for me. You can hang on to your whites, thank you very much.

The travel was stressful too. Test series, especially those not at home, became a bit of a drag for me, for several reasons: the long tours, the non-stop travel, staying away from home and family for several weeks. Also, I'd entered the Test world a bit late, after 50-odd ODIs, by which time Test cricket was an add-on, not really what I was attuned to. Maybe if I'd debuted in Tests earlier, I'd have been mentally at peace with the format. (But if I start talking about how my career was mismanaged by the PCB, there will be hell to pay and another book altogether to publish.)